

OBITUARIES

He was the last of the Gandhians, a social reformer who transformed millions of lives with his selfless and tireless work among the least privileged. Unlike most social activists, Murlidhar Devidas Amte, a.k.a. Baba Amte, founded institutions to help those rejected by society. His commune for leprosy patients, Anandvan Ashram at Warora in the Chandrapur district of Maharashtra, is living testimony to his ideals. Baba Amte's presence and power illuminated many lives as he strived to ensure a life of dignity for the discriminated, deprived and dispossessed.

A lawyer-turned-activist, he staked his life in serving society in an exemplary manner by leading a spartan life—a home with just two rooms with no comforts except a fan and a TV set—that prompted his doctor sons Prakash and Vikas, to tread the same path of service to humanity by working among the hapless tribals of Chandrapur and contiguous Gadchiroli. Baba Amte was a freedom fighter whom



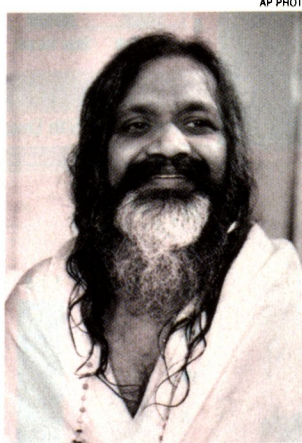
Baba Amte
1914-2008

Gandhiji called "abhay sadhak" (fearless seeker of truth). He went to the Kolkata School of Tropical Medicine and learnt to treat patients with the wonder drug diamino diphenyl sulphone before spending his life serving leprosy patients and working for their rehabilitation at a time when society shunned lepers. Baba Amte wore honours and awards lightly and always appeared in a coarse cotton tunic and shorts. He contracted leprosy twice, was bitten by a cobra thrice and suffered spinal damage. He was confined to a mobile stretcher after his spine gave way, before blood cancer eventually claimed him.

Some of his ambitions like launching a Bharat Jodo campaign by setting up youth centres to unite people across the length and breadth of the country and visiting Pakistan for peace and harmony remain unfulfilled. Yet, the commitment and grit he displayed all through his life is why he is revered as a saint and messiah. Baba Amte's legacy will serve as an inspiration for generations to come. **by Amarnath K. Menon**

The itinerant globe trotter, the flying yogi sold a canny mix of Indian spirituality and mysticism to a largely Western audience that inspired a cult following in the 1960s and '70s. His followers included Beatles, Mick Jagger of the Rolling Stones and Indo-American author Deepak Chopra. Some called him the Giggling Guru for his high-pitched laugh that often characterised his observations. Born Mahesh Prasad Varma, he studied mathematics and physics at the Allahabad University, little aware that even as a non-Brahmin, he would go

on to become Maharishi Mahesh Yogi and the architect of the hoary concept of a higher state of consciousness which he called Transcendental Meditation (TM). Unfazed by his failure to succeed the Shankaracharya of the Jyotir Math Swami Brahmanand Saraswati and, later, in a much publicised attempt at levitation, he made Hindu seem synonymous with Hippie and capitalised on the need for meditation in the West. He dispelled the perception that meditation took



Maharishi Mahesh Yogi
1917-2008

one to renunciation and instead presented it as an exhilarating addition to an active life that enhanced the qualities of human living. He wanted to be seen as a messiah. The Maharishi laid the foundation for a new world based on the knowledge of Vedas and spirituality. He was most comfortable in the company of Indians with whom he chatted about familiar issues. The irony is that while he spoke about the vows of poverty and celibacy, the entrepreneur of enlightenment lived in luxury in the Netherlands where he built his plush headquarters and amassed

considerable wealth for the TM movement besides building a \$300 million (Rs 1,200 crore) empire. His journey on earth finally ended where it began, in Allahabad, where his remains were brought from the Netherlands for the final rites at Sangam, the confluence of three holy rivers. Now his followers, known as rajas, will continue his work, aiming at peace and healing through meditation.

by Amarnath K. Menon

Hand in Glove

LUCKNOW The unearthing of a conspiracy by the Special Task Force (STF) behind the sensational terrorist attack on a CRPF camp in Rampur has once again exposed the cooperation of local youth with Pakistan-based terrorist outfits. Seven jawans were shot dead by the terrorists when they attacked the camp in the wee hours on January 1.



The CRPF camp in Rampur

Amitabh Yash, SSP, STF, who is leading the probe, told INDIA TODAY that Sahabuddin, alias Abu Qasim, was also involved in the attack on the Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore in December 2005 in which one scientist was killed and a professor injured. Qasim, who led the Rampur attack, was arrested in Lucknow along with Abu Jar and Abu Sama while he was boarding a train to Mumbai to carry out similar attacks at BSE and other vital points. Faheem Ahmad Ansari, Mohammad Sharif and Baba were arrested from Rampur. All of them belong to Lashkar-e-Toiba. Jar is a trained computer software engineer. "This is a disturbing trend when well-educated boys from relatively good families are joining terrorist ranks," laments a senior STF officer.

by Subhash Mishra